History of interactive media & games



Image: *Serial Experiments Lain* (1998)

COMM 2003

History of Interactive Media and Games
Dr. Martin Roberts
Communications Media Department
Fitchburg State University
Fall 2026, 3 credits

Thu 3 Sept---Fri 11 Dec 2026 | Fridays 14:00-15:15 | Conlon Hall 341
Office hrs: Friday 16:00-17:00 (via Zoom)
Blackboard | Syllabus (PDF)

Overview

This course examines the history and historiography of interactive media. Students will explore what interactivity has been, is and might become. This class provides a wide-ranging history of the uses, effects and design of interactive media from their beginnings to the present. Students will study the history of the functions and forms of interactive systems thereby better equipping them as users as well as potential designers of interactive media. This course is required for majors and for game design majors. ART. Prerequisite(s): ENGL 1100

Objectives

Films

- *LIFE 2.0* (Jason Spingarn-Koff, 2010)

Assignments & Evaluation

- **Commentary** (Blackboard or Canvas, weekly, 10 required: 100-250-word response to reading/screening assignments): 30%
- **Midterm: Game Report/Analysis**
- **Special Interest Group (SIG) Paper** (open topic) (1,000 words, 4 pages double-spaced, not including bibliography, letter grade): 15%
- **Special Interest Group (SIG) Presentation** (in-class, slides optional but not required): 15%
- **Final: Game Report/Analysis**: (1,000 words / 4 pages double-spaced): 20%

Schedule

Week 1 | F 09/04

Introduction: Graceful Degradation

Sandy Stone, “Sex, Death, and Machinery” (in *The War of Desire and Technology at the Close of the Mechanical Age*)

See W1 Introduction.

Week 2 | F 09/11

Adventure Games

- Nick Montfort, “Adventure and Its Ancestors” (*Twisty Little Passages*, ch. 3)
- Lebling, P. David, Marc S. Blank, and Timothy A. Anderson, “Zork: A Computerized Fantasy Simulation Game” (*IEEE Computer*, April 1979, pp. 51-59)

Week 3 | F 09/18

Hyperfiction

- Nick Montfort, “Zork and other Mainframe Works” (*Twisty Little Passages*, ch. 4)

Week 4 | F 09/25

Turing Test

- Sarah Ciston et al., “Please Go On: An Introduction”, in *Inventing ELIZA: How The First Chatbot Shaped the Future of AI*.
- Loebner Prize

Week 5 | F 10/02

Habitat: Democracy in Cyberspace

Video: Lucasfilm's *Habitat* promo

- Chip Morningstar and F. Randall Farmer, "The Lessons of Lucasfilm's Habitat" (in *Cyberspace: First Steps*, edited by Michael Benedikt, MIT Press, 1991, pp. 273-300)
- Dibbell, Julian. "A Rape in Cyberspace." *The Village Voice*, December 21, 1993.
- Martin Roberts et al., *Democracy in Cyberspace*. MIT Communications Forum, 1994.
- How to log on to LambdaMOO

Week 6 | F 10/09

Myst

See W6 Avatars.

Videos: *Myst* (2)

- Myst
- Play online

Week 7 | F 10/16

Second Lives

- "Double Agents" (*New York Times*, 15 June 2007)
- Thomas Malaby, *Making Virtual Worlds: Linden Labs and Second Life*:
  - "The Product: Second Life, Capital, and the Possibility of Failure in a Virtual World" (ch. 1)
  - "Knowing the Gamer from the Game" (ch. 3)
  - "References"
- Second Life (try setting up an account!)
- *LIFE 2.0* (documentary about *Second Life*)

Week 8 | F 10/23

VRChat

- Screening: *We Met in Virtual Reality* (documentary, Joe Hunting, 2022)
- Hyperallergic article
- Hunting interview

Week 9 | F 10/30

Virtual Psychogeography

Videos: *Cyberpunk 2077* (2)

- Stephen Johnson, "Watch how video games are approaching perfect photorealism" (*Freethink*, 30 September 2023)
- "The Truth About the Modded *Cyberpunk 2077* Hyperrealism Fad" (*Medium*, 19 April 2024)
- "The Ultimate Cyberpunk 2077 PC Modding Guide: Looks, Performance & Customization" (*Medium*, 19 April 2024)
- Alexandra Sakellariou, "RDR2 Prioritizes Realism At The Expense of Playability" (*Screen Rant*, 7 September 2020)
- *Cyberpunk 2077* (*Nexus Mods*)
- *Cyberpunk 2077* YouTube playlist
- inZOI

Week 10 | F 11/06

Generative Worlds

- Fei Fei Li, "From Words to Worlds: Spatial Intelligence is AI's Next Frontier" (World Labs, 10 November 2025)
- "Marble: A Multimodal World Model" (World Labs, 12 November 2025)
- "3D As Code" (World Labs, 3 March 2026)

Week 11 | F 11/13

Photorealistic Worlds

- "Atlas: A World Model for Spatial Intelligence" (World Labs, 1 September 2026)
- "A Functional Taxonomy of World Models" (World Labs, 3 June 2026)

Week 12 | F 11/20

Agents

Introduction to Agentic AI - Claude Code, Hermes. etc.

Week 13 | F 11/27

NO CLASS (Thanksgiving recess, T 11/24 4:45 p.m. to Sun 11/29)

Week 14 | F 12/04

SIG Presentations

DEADLINE: Special Interest Group (SIG) presentations

Week 15 | F 12/11

SIG Presentations

M 12/14 Reading Day

T 12/15-21 Exam period (T 12/22 snow day)

Bibliography

- Ian Bogost and Nick Montfort. *Racing the Beam: The Atari Video Computer System*. MIT Press, 2009.
- Sarah Ciston, David M. Berry, Anthony C. Hay, Mark C. Marino, Peter Millican, Jeff Shrager, Arthur I. Schwarz and Peggy Weil, *Inventing ELIZA: How The First Chatbot Shaped the Future of AI*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2026.
- Thomas M. Malaby. *Making Virtual Worlds: Linden Lab and Second Life*. Cornell University Press, 2009.
- Nick Montfort. *Twisty Little Passages: An Approach to Interactive Fiction.* MIT Press, 2005.
- Allucquère Rosanne Stone. *The War of Desire and Technology at the Close of the Mechanical Age*. MIT Press, 1995.
- Sherry Turkle. *Life on the Screen: Identity in the Age of the Internet*. Simon & Schuster, 1995.

Policies

Late Policy

Assignments that are late will lose 1/2 of a grade per day, beginning at the end of class and including weekends and holidays. This means that a paper, which would have received an A if it was on time, will receive a B+ the next day, B- for two days late, and so on. Time management, preparation for our meetings, and timely submission of your work comprise a significant dimension of your professionalism. As such, your work must be completed by the beginning of class on the day it is due. If you have a serious problem that makes punctual submission impossible, you must discuss this matter with me before the due date so that we can make alternative arrangements. Because you are given plenty of time to complete your work, and major due dates are given to you well in advance, last minute problems should not preclude handing in assignments on time.

Mandatory Reporter

Fitchburg State University is committed to providing a safe learning environment for all students that is free of all forms of discrimination and harassment. Please be aware all FSU faculty members are “mandatory reporters,” which means that if you tell me about a situation involving sexual harassment, sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, or stalking, I am legally required to share that information with the Title IX Coordinator. If you or someone you know has been impacted by sexual harassment, sexual assault, dating or domestic violence, or stalking, FSU has staff members trained to support you. If you or someone you know has been impacted by sexual harassment, sexual assault, dating or domestic violence, or stalking, please visit http://fitchburgstate.edu/titleix to access information about university support and resources.

Health

Health Services

Hours: Monday-Friday 8:30AM-5PM Location: Ground Level of Russell Towers (across from the entrance of Holmes Dining Hall) Phone: (978) 665-3643/3894

Counseling Services

The Counseling Services Office offers a range of services including individual, couples and group counseling, crisis intervention, psychoeducational programming, outreach ALTERNATIVE ECOSYSTEMSs, and community referrals. Counseling services are confidential and are offered at no charge to all enrolled students. Staff at Counseling Services are also available for consultation to faculty, staff and students. Counseling Services is located in the Hammond, 3rd Floor, Room 317.

Fitchburg Anti-Violence Education (FAVE)

FAVE collaborates with a number of community partners (e.g., YWCA Domestic Violence Services, Pathways for Change) to meet our training needs and to link survivors with community based resources. This site also features resources for help or information about dating violence, domestic violence, sexual assault and stalking. If you or someone you know is in an abusive relationship or has been a victim of sexual assault, there are many places to go for help. Many can be accessed 24 hours a day, seven days a week, 365 days a year. On campus, free and confidential support is provided at both Counseling Services and Health Services.

Community Food Pantry Food insecurity is a growing issue and it certainly can affect student learning. The ability to have access to nutritious food is incredibly vital. The Falcon Bazaar, located in Hammond G 15, is stocked with food, basic necessities, and can provide meal swipes to support all Fitchburg State students experiencing food insecurity for a day or a semester.

The university continues to partner with Our Father's House to support student needs and access to food and services. All Fitchburg State University students are welcome at the Our Father's House Community Food Pantry. This Pantry is located at the Faith Christian Church at 40 Boutelle St., Fitchburg, MA and is open from 5-7pm. Each "household" may shop for nutritious food once per month by presenting a valid FSU ID.

Academic Integrity

The University "Academic Integrity" policy can be found online at http:// www.fitchburgstate.edu/offices-services-directory/office-of-student-conductmediation-education/academic-integrity/. Students are expected to do their own work. Plagiarism and cheating are inexcusable. Any instance of plagiarism or cheating will automatically result in a zero on the assignment and may be reported the Office of Student and Academic Life at the discretion of the instructor.

Plagiarism includes, but is not limited to: - Using papers or work from another class. - Using another student's paper or work from any class. - Copying work or a paper from the Internet. - The egregious lack of citing sources or documenting research.

If you're not clear on what is or is not plagiarism, ASK. The BEST case scenario if caught is a zero on that assignment, and ignorance of what does or does not count is not an excuse. That being said, I'm a strong supporter of Fair Use doctrine. Just attribute what you use—and, again, ASK if there's any doubt.

Americans With Disabilities Act (ADA)

If you need course adaptations or accommodations because of a disability, if you have emergency medical information to share with the instructor, or if you need special arrangements in case the building must be evacuated, please inform the faculty member as soon as possible.

Technology

At some point during the semester you will likely have a problem with technology. Your laptop will crash; your iPad battery will die; a recording you make will disappear; you will accidentally delete a file; the wireless will go down at a crucial time. These, however, are inevitabilities of life, not emergences. Technology problems are not excuses for unfinished or late work. Bad things may happen, but you can protect yourself by doing the following:

- Plan ahead: A deadline is the last minute to turn in material. You can start---and finish---early, particularly if challenging resources are required, or you know it will be time consuming to finish this project.
- Save work early and often: Think how much work you do in 10 minutes. I auto save every 2 minutes.

- Make regular backups of files in a different location: Between Box, Google Drive, Dropbox, and iCloud, you have ample places to store and backup your materials. Use them.
- Save drafts: When editing, set aside the original and work with a copy.
- Practice safe computing: On your personal devices, install and use software to control viruses and malware.

Grading

Grading for the course will follow the FSU grading policy below:

4.0: 95-100
3.7: 92-94
3.5: 89-91
3.3: 86-88
3.0: 83-85
2.7: 80-82
2.5: 77-79
2.3: 74-76
2.0: 71-73
0.0: < 70

Academic Resources

Writing Center

Academic Policies

Disability Services

Fitchburg State Alert system for emergencies, snow closures/delays, and faculty absences

University Career Services